

Rep. Tom Emmer on Fox 9

Fox 9 Local

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COURTNEY:

Representative Emmer, thank you for joining us this afternoon, we sure appreciate you making the time.

REP. TOM EMMER:

Good to be with you, Courtney.

COURTNEY:

Tom, you were in attendance at the White House Correspondents' Dinner on Saturday night. We're so grateful that you and everyone else in the ballroom and at that hotel is okay, but can you take me to Saturday night, what you witnessed, what you heard?

REP. TOM EMMER:

There were somewhere between 2,500 and 3,000 people on the floor of the ballroom. It was so tight, you couldn't move around, really, you couldn't move around easily. And it was just starting. The president and the first lady had arrived, the vice president was there, the chairman of the event, the president from CBS, she was giving her remarks and things were just moving along. The salad had begun, right? And then I heard some distinct shots that were coming from the back of the room. I was looking at the president who seemed very stoic and the first lady who looked like she went on point, looking at the back door in the center of the ballroom. And I turned to look and see where it was coming from. That's where you saw people starting to scramble away from the door and, you know, different people process it differently, Courtney, and clearly it was a dangerous situation until it was under control. So the initial response was varied, but a lot of people, I think, experienced some serious trauma having never gone through that before.

COURTNEY:

The shooter said he was targeting officials from highest ranking to lowest. You are the majority whip. Do you believe that you are one of the targets?

REP. TOM EMMER:

I don't care. I'm going to tell you what I care about is the fact that our law enforcement performed as well as I've ever seen. There was layer upon layer of law enforcement. At one point, I asked the question about it looks like a third of this room is security. There was an enormous number of officers on the floor in the in the ballroom. And you see this this coward, whatever he was going to do, he was unable to accomplish it because he ran past one magnetometer, shot an officer in the chest. Thankfully, he was wearing a bulletproof vest and he has survived. And then the second that he started getting returned fire, he dropped to the ground and they took him into custody. So I look, I think there is no place in this society for political violence. And I think the most important lesson of the other night is we all have to do a better job of watching the the rhetoric that drives these

sort of things. And frankly, as a member from Minnesota, Melissa Hortman and I were elected together back in 2004. And we were sworn in together in 2005. We we know firsthand that this is very dangerous. It's time that we return. And I love, by the way, rambling a little bit, Courtney, but it's because I love the response of the president afterward. You know, this is a an event to celebrate the First Amendment in this country, and we're not going to let people stop us from doing that. And we're going to protect everyone's right to speak freely. So I think that's the lesson to get from the other night.

COURTNEY:

Well, and speaking of Melissa Hortman and her husband who were killed last year here on a state level, lawmakers are proposing several bills that would increase security for any constitutional offer. Legislature who is the target of a credible threat. Do you think that we need to increase security? I mean, we have more than 40 lawmakers here on a state level at the legislature who are not are choosing not to seek reelection. Of course, we don't know why, but we're kind of living in a time, Tom, where it's like who wants to run for office when there's this much political violence out there? What do you think needs to be done?

REP. TOM EMMER:

Well, this isn't necessarily about more security around elected officials. This is a societal problem for me. I mean, we're finding out that this 31 year old adult was living with his parents in California, that he was purchasing weapons and he was storing them in their house. And they say they didn't know about it. Well, this had to be going on for quite some time. I think more information has to come out about the red flags that were out there on this California crazy that decided to make violence part of his mission. We've got to do a better job as a society amongst our families, our neighborhoods, our communities of identifying when people are going off the rails. And clearly you're hearing about his manifesto now. He didn't just create this in one day. This stuff has been out there. Certainly someone sees it. It's like these incidents that we've had in Minnesota, these tragic incidents, including the shooting at Annunciation. These warnings were out there. People need to be either trained or we need to do a better job of identifying when someone is starting to escalate and go off the rails. And we need to make sure that they're not only identified and that the appropriate authorities are given a heads up, but that someone intervene and start to provide these people with the help that they need before they become violent.

COURTNEY:

The Institute for Strategic Dialogue says threats against public officials more than tripled from 2021 to 2025, and they're up against both parties. We heard acting AG Todd Blanche say just a little bit ago, law enforcement did not fail. But Tom, we have an individual who was able to book a hotel room at that hotel. He was able to run through security. He was able to get into that hotel with multiple guns and knives. Do you think that there is room for improvement here? Is this a learning experience?

REP. TOM EMMER:

I think every event, Courtney, is one of learning, no matter how good it is. You can always, after an event, reevaluate, look at, by the way, this guy checked in. We don't know the details of that. We don't know how he smuggled this, these weapons in. I mean, knives, that whole thing. The ballroom was secure, as is evidenced by the fact that he had to run past a magnetometer and start firing at least once before he was fired upon. He was not going to get to the ballroom. Whatever he was trying to do was never going to happen, which is probably the other reason that he just collapsed to the floor and surrendered. You can always learn from every event. It's an interesting time, no doubt, but we can't become prisoners of our own safety and security. We've got to do a better job of identifying these crazy, mentally disturbed people before they become violent and actually make

that next step, like this poor, deranged individual decided to do on Saturday night.

COURTNEY:

Trump has said this is a good reason why his ballroom should be supported, the construction of the ballroom, that it would be safer to be holding events like this at a ballroom at the White House. Do you think that this helps his case for the construction of that ballroom?

REP. TOM EMMER:

Certainly. I mean, the ballroom, I don't understand the objection to improving a ballroom that is unable to hold the state dinners that they have. They have to literally put a tent up out on the lawn. This has been something that others, long before President Trump, talked about doing as an improvement to the White House. Certainly Saturday night would show you, even though I don't have a problem with the Hilton or the security that was provided, but I think the point was made that it's got the most rooms in Washington, D.C. of any hotel and they all sit above the ballroom. So as you pointed out just earlier, this person was able to check into a hotel room and just presumably take an elevator down or the stairs and try to gain access. So certainly putting it in the White House, where it's the most secure place perhaps in the world, is going to be an improvement.

COURTNEY:

Well, it's interesting to me, Tom, that you say you have no issue with the security at the Hilton. The president himself said he wanted to see what was going on. He asked his security to wait a minute. You know the president very well. Does this surprise you, the way that he wanted to see what was going on before they rushed him out and then held a press conference in his tuxedo right after?

REP. TOM EMMER:

Yeah, no, it doesn't surprise me at all. I mean, this is a man that has had more assassination attempts than anyone, I think, in our history, one of which somehow, by the grace of God, he managed to survive. The president is amazing in terms of he's going to make sure that he understands what's going on. He doesn't panic. This is not a man who suddenly jumps and runs. You saw after the Bedminster shooting, he stood up and pumped his fist in the air three times yelling, fight, fight, fight. He loves this country and he's not going to back down. He wants Americans to be safe. Clearly, he wanted everybody in that room to be safe, even people that he disagrees with and frankly dislike him like no other. He felt for everyone in the room, which is why I think you heard him say after, I had a much different speech that I was going to give tonight. I think when we do this again, it'll be a little bit different speech in terms of we're all in this together. No, he did the right thing. I think everybody did. Everybody again processes in the way that they process. He's amazing that he wanted to come back and do the event the same night because frankly, he doesn't want cowards and deranged individuals literally defining what our freedom is going to look like.

COURTNEY:

Well, business as usual, I guess. Any concern about King Charles visit this week?

REP. TOM EMMER:

Well, I'm sure that the security will be heightened. These events, you know, we have major events all the time here in Washington and all across the country. And I think, Courtney, you will see once again a heightened sense of scrutiny and eyes on the event and checking people that are coming into the event. But no, I expect the King to be very safe and I expect members of Congress to be safe as well. And any visitors that we have on

the campus this week.

COURTNEY:

Well, Tom, I get the vibe from you that none of this can scare you away from running for office. It sounds like you're here to stay. Shooter can't scare you.

REP. TOM EMMER:

Well, I'm not going to take that kind of a bravado. For me, look, it's it's important that we do what we're doing and we need to set an example and show people that we can disagree in this country. We can disagree vigorously. But the point is, we can sit down after and understand that while we have disagreements, we still live in the same place. We still love the same country. And we just got to keep setting that example. And soon, I think the the generations to come. This will improve.

COURTNEY:

All right. Representative Tom Emmer, Majority Whip, we appreciate you joining us today to debrief about the shooting where you were present on Saturday. Thank you for making the time.

REP. TOM EMMER:

Thank you, Courtney.

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